

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

TUESDAY, JANUARY 7, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump's victory peacefully certified

Transfer of power completed without challenge, violence

By Lisa Mascaro,
Mary Clare Jalonick,
Farnoush Amiri
and Matt Brown
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Congress certified President-elect Donald Trump as the winner of the 2024 election in proceedings that unfolded Monday without chal-

lenge, in stark contrast to the Jan. 6, 2021, violence as his mob of supporters stormed the Capitol. Lawmakers convened under heavy security and a snowstorm to meet the date required by law to certify the election. The whole process happened swiftly and without unrest. But the legacy of Jan. 6, 2021, leaves an extraordinary fact: The candidate who tried

to overturn the previous election won this time and is legitimately returning to power. Vice President Kamala Harris, presiding over proceedings as the role of her office, read the tally, including of her own defeat. The chamber broke into applause, first Republicans for Trump's 312 electoral votes, then Democrats for Harris' 226.

Within half an hour the process was done. But as lawmakers gathered, layers of tall black fencing were flanking the U.S. Capitol complex in a stark reminder of what happened four years ago, when a defeated Trump sent his mob to "fight like hell" in what became the most gruesome attack on the seat of American democracy in 200 years. Republicans who challenged the 2020 results when Trump lost to

Democrat Joe Biden now express greater trust in U.S. elections after he defeated Harris. And Democrats frustrated by Trump's victory nevertheless accept the choice of the American voters, the House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries saying his side of the aisle is not "infested" with election deniers. One by one, the state results were read aloud by the tellers as

Turn to Trump, Page 10



JoAngel Tapia, 7, gets a kiss from his mother, Beatrice Garcia, on Dec. 18 outside Henderson Elementary, where Jeannie Carrasquillo works as a special education classroom assistant. ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Crossroads of care

Special education assistants and teacher aides at odds amid CPS cuts

By Nell Salzman | Chicago Tribune

Beatrice Garcia credits the special education classroom assistants at Henderson Elementary in Englewood for helping her son speak. "He hasn't been verbal," said Garcia. "But now that he's been with (the SECAs), he wants to interact with me, he wants to interact with his brother. And he was not showing any of these signs last year at all." Having professionals at school she can trust is an immense help to Garcia, a single mother with two sons under the age of 10. Her youngest, JoAngel Tapia, 7, was diagnosed with autism when he was 2. But Garcia worries special education funding challenges at Chicago Public Schools may jeopardize JoAngel's ability to have an assistant who can support him.

After hundreds of teacher assistants were laid off at the beginning of last year, CTU ramped up proposals in its ongoing contract talks to consider hiring them to support students with disabilities. Special education classroom assistants — a different type of CPS aide represented by a different union — expressed concerns about what hiring teacher assistants for their role would do to the quality of care provided to students with complex needs. In early December, Service Employees International Union Local 73, the union that

represents special education classroom assistants, threatened a lawsuit over the dispute, which it said would take work from SEIU members. According to recent data from CPS, there are currently fewer than 1,000 teacher assistants and about 7,000 special education classroom assistants. While the conflict has big financial implications for total dues payment amounts in both unions, parents, students and special education teacher assistants say they are stuck in the crosshairs. The two roles are similar but

Turn to CPS, Page 2

MICHAEL MADIGAN
TRIAL

Ex-chief counsel to Madigan testifies

Says speaker had protocols to avoid conflicts of interest

By Jason Meisner,
Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

After an extended 18-day holiday break in testimony, attorneys for ex-House Speaker Michael Madigan on Monday unveiled a new prong of their defense: that the speaker had long-established protocols to prevent conflicts of interest between his government work and his private law practice. The defense also called witnesses intended to rebut other elements of the prosecution's case, including that Madigan's aides helped carry ComEd legislation across the finish line in 2016 and that the speaker had told a longtime precinct captain in 2018 to keep working on political campaigns even though he was being paid as a subcontractor by the utility. It amounted to a disjointed day of testimony in the trial, which began Oct. 8 and is inching toward a conclusion, with closing arguments possible as soon as next week. Before the jury was sent home for the holidays Dec. 19, the case's spotlight had finally turned to Madigan's defense team, whose witnesses so far have offered a far different picture of the powerful Democratic speaker than the image painted by prosecutors of a conniving and opportunistic political machine boss. On Monday morning, Madigan's attorneys told U.S. District Judge John Robert Blakey that they intended to disprove prosecutors' allegations that Madigan supported legislation to transfer

Turn to Madigan, Page 4

City-owned grocery future in doubt

Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson's administration passed on applying for state funding for a city-owned grocery store, raising questions about the future of the bold proposal the mayor floated more than a year ago. **Business**

Grant Park Music Festival announces new season

The Grant Park Music Festival announced its 2025 season, the first season under new music director Giancarlo Guerrero. The lineup reflects Guerrero's interest in contemporary American fare — and, broadly, the festival's, as a longtime programming plank of director Carlos Kalmar before him. **Arts & Living**

CTA to lock in Red Line funding in advance of Trump



A CTA Red Line train sits on March 10, 2023, below the current southern terminus near the 95th Street station. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By Sarah Freisstat
Chicago Tribune

The CTA is set to formally lock in needed federal money for the extension of the Red Line before President-elect Donald Trump takes office, paving the way for the long-planned addition through Chicago's Far South Side to move forward. A large, nearly \$2 billion federal grant, key to moving the \$5.3 billion project forward, had been promised to the CTA but the formal agreement not yet signed. That put the transit agency under pressure to finalize the agreement before the change in administration and a Republican-controlled Congress could potentially throw the commitment into jeopardy. But the CTA and the Federal Transit Administration plan to sign the agreement Friday, a little more than a week before Trump is inau-

Turn to Red Line, Page 5

